Kona Village, Rosewood
Research Plan and Research Instruments
DSM-550-F26 - Analytics and Research Methodology

Audrey Zhong, Victoria Dong, Kylie Feng, Jenny Zhang, Avery Liu
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1. **Background & Business Challenge**

   1.1 Context

   Hawaii Island welcomed 1.75 million visitors in 2025, who spent $3.23 billion on the island, and the U.S. West remains Hawai‘i’s largest and highest-spending visitor market (Department of Business, Economic Development and Tourism [DBEDT], 2026). Within this market, Kona Village, A Rosewood Resort, is a luxury beachfront resort on Hawai‘i Island’s Kona Coast that reopened under Rosewood in July 2023 after being closed since 2011 (Rosewood Hotels & Resorts, 2023). Because the resort is only three years into its new chapter, most luxury travelers considering a Hawai‘i Island trip have never stayed there. Its growth therefore depends on attracting first-time guests rather than relying on a base of returning visitors.

   Kona Village’s brand emphasizes Hawaiian heritage, a connection to nature, and standalone hale accommodations, bungalows designed to blend into the surrounding lava landscape (Rosewood Hotels & Resorts, n.d.). However, it competes for these same travelers with Four Seasons Resort Hualālai, an established neighbor on the same coast that is priced at near parity and also promotes Hawaiian culture through its Ka‘ūpūlehu Cultural Center (Four Seasons Hotels and Resorts, n.d.). When two resorts offer a similar setting, price, and cultural story, a prospective guest without firsthand experience has little basis to choose between them other than what marketing and other guests say.

   To understand what actually differentiates Kona Village in guests’ own words, we analyzed Expedia guest reviews for Kona Village (n = 63) and Four Seasons Hualālai (n = 100), coding the themes guests discuss most when describing their stay. These reviews matter for two reasons: they show which experiences past guests value, and they are the same content new travelers read when deciding whether a resort is worth considering.



Figure 1. Expedia Guest Review Analysis of Kona Village and Four Seasons Hualālai

1.2 Business Challenge

Guest reviews reveal a mismatch between what Kona Village markets as its core differentiator and what guests actually highlight as its strengths.

Kona Village's brand positioning centers on its distinctive property design and place-specific legacy, yet reviews mentioning "Property, Setting & Rooms" are nearly identical between Kona Village (57%) and Four Seasons Hualālai (58%); this intended point of differentiation is not registering as distinctive in guests' own words. By contrast, Kona Village's largest advantages appear in dimensions the brand does not foreground: guests mention "Dining & Food" far more often than at Four Seasons (32% vs. 19%), and "Service & Staff" somewhat more often (52% vs. 46%). Kona Village also trails on "Amenities & Activities" (23.8% vs. 27%). If Kona Village continues to market itself around its property and setting while guests are actually responding to its dining and service, its messaging may fail to attract new

travelers, who—lacking firsthand experience—rely on this kind of review and social content to decide whether to consider booking.

2. North Star Research Objectives

2.1 Business Objective

How might Kona Village realign its marketing messaging with the experiences guests actually value most to more effectively attract new luxury travelers who have never stayed there?

2.2 Research Objective

To identify which hotel experiences and attributes luxury travelers value most, and to understand how Kona Village can highlight these to attract new travelers who have never stayed there.

2.3 Research Questions

RQ1: What hotel experiences and attributes most influence luxury travelers' decisions when choosing a resort like Kona Village?

RQ2: Among these experiences and attributes, which ones are most likely to attract new luxury travelers who have never stayed at Kona Village?

3. Research Population & Sample Specifications

3.1 Research Population

Our target population consists of U.S.-based, high-net-worth leisure travelers, aged 25–64, with an annual household income of $180,000 or higher, who have taken at least one ultra-luxury resort stay (averaging $800+ per night) within the past 24 months. This population actively researches, considers, or books Hawaii Island ultra-luxury resorts such as Kona Village and its direct competitors, including Four Seasons Resort Hualālai. Within this population, we expect two broad travel occasions to be represented: couples and honeymooners planning a once-in-a-lifetime splurge trip, and multigenerational families traveling with children and/or parents who prioritize space and privacy. Most members of this

population are not yet guests of Kona Village, making their awareness, perceptions, and decision-making process especially relevant to our research objective.

3.2 Sample Specifications

- **Age:** 25–64 years old
- **Household Income:** $180,000 or more annually.
- **Travel Behavior:** At least one leisure resort stay averaging $800+ per night within the past 24 months.
- **Geography:**U.S.-based travelers, with targeted recruitment from West Coast markets (CA, WA, OR).
- **Resort Consideration:** Have previously stayed at, researched, or considered an ultra-luxury resort on Hawai‘i Island.

3.3 Sampling Rationale & Limitations

The age range of 25–64 and household income threshold of $180,000+ are intended to identify financially qualified luxury travelers. U.S. Census Bureau (2025) household income data provide context for the age distribution of high-income households, supporting the relevance of this target demographic. Requiring at least one luxury resort stay averaging $800+ per night within the past 24 months helps ensure participants have recent experience with premium hospitality. West Coast travelers will be prioritized due to their proximity to Hawai‘i and the region's importance to Hawai‘i tourism (DBEDT, 2026).

We will use non-probability purposive sampling, supplemented by snowball referrals, to reach this niche population. However, recruitment through online communities and personal networks may introduce selection bias and overrepresent digitally active travelers. Therefore, findings will provide directional insights rather than statistically representative estimates of the broader luxury travel market.

4. Research Methodology

4.1 Mixed-Methods Design Rationale

This study employs an exploratory sequential mixed-methods research design, beginning with qualitative semi-structured interviews followed by a quantitative survey.

The qualitative phase explores luxury travelers' decision-making processes, identifies the resort attributes they value most, and examines which experiences and marketing messages may attract first-time Kona Village guests. Findings from these interviews will inform the development of the quantitative survey, which will assess the relative importance and appeal of the identified attributes among a larger sample of potential travelers.

4.2 Methodological Integration & Alignment

Phase 1: Qualitative Interviews (N = 10–15)

Semi-structured depth interviews (approximately 30 minutes each) will explore travelers' resort selection criteria, underlying motivations, and perceptions of luxury resort experiences. Participants will primarily be prospective first-time Kona Village guests, including couples and family/multigenerational travelers, with 2–3 previous guests included for comparison. Interviews will also examine which attributes and messages are most appealing to travelers who have never stayed at Kona Village.

This phase will primarily address RQ1 and explore RQ2, while identifying key themes to inform the survey design.

Phase 2: Quantitative Survey (N = 100–150)

Building on the qualitative findings, a structured online survey will measure and rank the importance of identified resort attributes, such as dining quality, service excellence, privacy, and room design. The survey will target prospective first-time Kona Village guests, aiming for a balanced representation of couples and family/multigenerational travelers to explore differences in preferences. It will also evaluate which experiences and marketing messages are most appealing to these potential guests.

This phase will quantify findings related to both RQ1 and RQ2 and identify potential differences across traveler segments.

4.3 Integration of Findings

Qualitative interviews will be conducted first to identify key decision-making factors and potential messaging opportunities. These findings will guide the development of the quantitative questionnaire. Survey results will then assess how widely these preferences are shared across the target sample, helping identify which resort experiences Kona Village should prioritize in its marketing messaging.

4.4 **Sample Source & Recruitment Plan**

We will use non-probability purposive sampling (enforcing strict income and travel screening) combined with snowball sampling (leveraging advisor networks and referrals).

Recruitment Channel	Target Platform / Location	Execution Strategy
Reddit & Travel Forums	r/FATTravel, r/chubbytravel, TripAdvisor	Post moderator-approved screener for paid 30-minute interviews.
Social Media Hashtags	Instagram, Xiaohongshu, Threads	DM users who publicly indicate a recent stay at relevant luxury resorts.
Advisor & Alumni Networks	Virtuoso FB Groups, USC Alumni	Share screener link and request warm client referrals.
In-Person Field Intercepts	SoCal Luxury Resort Lounges/Bars	Brief on-site screening and intercept interviews with target travelers.

5. Timeline, Deliverables & Expected Outcomes

a. Research Timeline

Phase 1 (Weeks 8–9): Qualitative Interviews.

Phase 2 (Weeks 9–11): Thematic Analysis & Survey Refinement

Phase 3 (Weeks 11–12): Quantitative Survey

Phase 4 (Weeks 13–14): Integrated Analysis & Final Report

b. **Deliverables & Expected Outcomes:** We will deliver a quantitative dataset, a qualitative insight deck, and a final strategic report. The expected outcomes are to identify the resort experiences and marketing messages most appealing to potential first-time guests, helping Kona Village strengthen its competitive differentiation and attract new luxury travelers.

Qualitative Interview Guide

Format: 30-minute semi-structured, one-on-one depth interview (Zoom or in person), recorded with consent

Participants: N = 10–15 U.S.-based HNW luxury travelers recruited via advisor networks, alumni channels, and travel forums, covering a mix of travel parties (couples, families, and multigenerational groups). Most will be non-guests of the sponsoring resort, plus 2–3 past guests as a contrast group.

Objectives: Explore the attributes and decision factors that matter most to luxury travelers (RQ1), and uncover decision friction, messaging resonance, and perception gaps among first-time prospects (RQ2). Findings will inform the quantitative survey.

Blind design: Interviewers never name the sponsoring resort or its competitor. All stimuli are unbranded and labeled Resort A and Resort B.

Stimulus materials: (1) Concept A and Concept B message cards; (2) two unbranded Instagram-style image sets (Resort A, Resort B); (3) 3–4 anonymized guest review excerpts per resort; (4) six attribute cards for the closing ranking exercise.

BEGINNING (6 min)

1. Research introduction (1 min)

> "Hi, thank you so much for joining today. My name is [Name], and I'm a graduate student at USC Annenberg. We're talking with travelers about how they choose and experience luxury resort vacations. Today is really about your own stories and opinions. We'll chat for about 30 minutes, and partway through I'll show you a few images and short messages to react to."

2. Research ethics and consent (1 min)

> "Before we start, a few things about how we'll handle what you share. With your permission, I'd like to record this session so I can focus on our conversation instead of taking notes. Only our five-person research team and our course instructor will hear the recording. We'll use it only for this class project. We'll quote you only anonymously, never by name, and we'll delete the recording by the end of this fall semester. You can skip any question or stop at any time. Do I have your consent to participate and to record?"

a. Record verbal consent at the start of the recording.
b. Do not collect PII beyond the first name. Remove names, employers and other identifying details from transcripts.
c. Confirm the incentive (gift cards) and when it will arrive.

3. Housekeeping rules (30 sec)

> "A few ground rules. There are no right or wrong answers. I didn't design anything you'll see today, so please be completely honest. Critical feedback is as helpful as praise. If you could silence your phone and notifications, that would be great. And if anything I ask is unclear, just tell me."

4. Participant introduction (1 min)

> "To start, tell me a little about yourself and who you usually travel with. If your ideal vacation were a movie, what would its title be, and who would be in the cast?"

Interviewer note: Silently confirm the screener data (travel party, guest or non-guest status). Do not read it aloud.

5. Warming up: broad and exploratory (2.5 min)

W1. Take me back to the most memorable luxury trip you've taken in the last few years. Walk me through the moment you knew it was special.

- *Probe:* What exactly happened? Who were you with? How much of that came from the place, the people, or something the staff did?

W2. Finish this sentence for me: "A resort that costs $2,000 a night should always…" Now tell me what separates that resort from a $600-a-night one.

- *Probe:* Where does that expectation come from?

KEY QUESTIONS (~18 min)

Interviewer note: Each topic builds on the one before it. The flow moves from how people decide, to what matters, to segment needs, to reactions to stimuli. Follow the participant's energy, but cover all four topics.

Topic A: The decision journey (RQ1) (4 min)

K1. Walk me through how you chose the last luxury resort you booked, from the first spark of inspiration to the moment you paid.

- *Probe:* Where did the idea first come from? Which sources did you lean on most: an advisor, social media, review sites, or the resort's own website? Why those?
- *Probe:* How did you narrow it down to your final two or three? What knocked the others out?

K2. Tell me about a moment in that process when you almost didn't book. What made you hesitate, and what got you past it?

K3. When you scroll through guest reviews or other travelers' posts, what are you hunting for? Describe a review that made you trust a place, and one that made you scroll right past it.

Topic B: What really matters (RQ1) (5 min)

K4. [Imagined scenario] Imagine it's day three of a stay at your dream resort, and you text a friend, "This place is worth every dollar." What just happened that made you send that?

- *Probe:* Why that moment? What would have made it fall flat?

K5. Describe the best meal you've had at a resort. What made it more than just good food?

- *Probe:* How did the setting, the staff, or the ingredients play into it? How much does a resort's dining shape whether you book it in the first place?

K6. Tell me about a time resort staff made you feel genuinely taken care of. What did they do differently?

- *Probe:* How would you describe the difference between service that feels personal and service that feels scripted?

K7. Many Hawaii resorts talk about their architecture, natural setting and cultural heritage. How do those things weigh in your decision, compared with what we just discussed?

- *Probe:* When you compare Hawaii resorts online, how do they start to blend together, and what, if anything, makes one stand out?

Topic C: Travel Party Needs & Concerns (RQ2) (4 min)

Interviewer note: Ask every participant the same questions. Use the probes to draw out details specific to their travel party (family, multigenerational, or couple).

K8. Think about the people you usually travel with. What has to be true about a resort before it makes your shortlist?

- *Probe:* What does each person in your group need to feel the trip was worth it? How do you balance private space with time together?

K9. [Projective] Imagine the last night of your next luxury trip. Describe the moment that tells you that you chose the right place.

- *Probe:* Who's there, and what's happening? What would make that moment fall flat?

K10. How do the sources you rely on, such as social media, reviews, or a travel advisor, shape what you expect from a resort before you arrive?

- *Probe:* Tell me about a time a place didn't live up to what you saw or heard, or exceeded it. When a resort's marketing seems aimed at a different kind of traveler than you, how does that affect your interest?

K11. What would make you worry you're paying a premium for something that won't deliver? How do you reassure yourself before booking?

Topic D: Perceptions and messaging (RQ2) (5 min)

K12. [Unaided recall, before any stimulus] If a friend asked you to recommend a luxury resort on Hawaii Island, which ones would you mention, and how would you describe each one to them?

- *Probe:* Where did you hear about these resorts? What do you remember most clearly about each one?

K13. [Visual stimulus] *Show the two unbranded image sets, labeled Resort A and Resort B.* If you had to book one of these for your next trip right now, which would you choose?

- *Probe:* Which photo made you decide? What do you think you'd spend most of your time doing there?
- *Probe:* In what ways do the two look similar?

K14. Looking at these photos, what can't you tell about each resort that you'd want to know before booking?

- *Probe:* For example, what the food is like, how the staff treat guests, or what there is to do. Which of these matters most to you?

K15. [Review stimulus] *Show the anonymized review excerpts.* Which review makes you most want to stay at that resort? Which line in it won you over?

- *Probe:* After reading the reviews, how has your choice of resort changed? What made you change your mind, or stick with your original choice?

K16. [Concept test] *Show the Concept A (property-centric) and Concept B (experience-centric) cards. Rotate their order across interviews.*

- Concept A: "Immerse yourself in authentic Hawaiian heritage and untouched natural beauty in our iconic standalone beachfront hales."
- Concept B: "Indulge in unscripted culinary craftsmanship and intuitive private service tailored to your personal preferences."
- If you came across these two as Instagram ads, which one would make you stop scrolling, and why?
- In each ad, which words stand out to you, good or bad?
- In the ad you prefer, what could be added that would make you click "book" right away?

END: WINDING DOWN (6 min)

E1. [Ranking exercise] *Lay out the six attribute cards: Culinary excellence and fine dining; Personalized, intuitive service; Room space, layout and privacy; Photogenic aesthetics and atmosphere; Standalone accommodations and natural setting; On-property activities and cultural programming.*

Based on everything we've talked about, please put these in order from most to least important when you choose a resort like this. Talk to me through your thinking as you go.

- *Probe:* What made your top choice beat number two? What would have to change for the bottom card to move up?

E2. Picture two resorts at exactly the same price. What would tip you toward one? And what, if anything, would make you willing to pay more for one?

E3. If you could give a luxury Hawai‘i resort's marketing team one piece of advice for reaching someone like you, what would it be?

E4. What else about choosing a resort like this matters to you that we haven't talked about?

E5. Close and participant questions

> "That's everything I had. Thank you so much for your time and your honesty. It's genuinely helpful. What questions do you have for me before we wrap up? As a reminder, your responses will stay anonymous, and your incentive will arrive within 5 days."

Quantitative Survey

Research Question 2: Among these experiences and attributes, which ones are most likely to attract new luxury travelers who have never stayed at Kona Village?

Target sample: U.S.-based travelers ages 25–64, annual household income $180,000+, at least one leisure resort stay averaging $800+/night within the past 24 months, and no prior Kona Village stay. Target N = 100–150.

Part 1. Survey Invitation

Hi! We are graduate students at the University of Southern California conducting an academic research project about luxury resort preferences and travel decision-making. We would love to hear about what matters most to you when choosing a luxury resort.

The survey takes approximately 8–10 minutes. Participation is voluntary, and your responses will be kept confidential and used only for academic research by our project team and instructor. No incentive is offered. Thank you for sharing your perspective!

Part 2. Screening Questions

S1. What is your age?
Select one

☐ Under 25

☐ 25–34

☐ 35–44

☐ 45–54

☐ 55–64

☐ 65 or older

☐ Prefer not to say

S2. Do you currently live in the United States?
Select one

☐ Yes

☐ No

S3. What is your annual household income before taxes?
Select one

☐ Under $180,000

☐ 180, 000–249,999

☐ $250,000 or more

☐ Prefer not to say

S4. In the past 24 months, have you stayed at a leisure resort with an average room rate of $800 or more per night?
Select one

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ Not sure

S5. Have you ever stayed at Kona Village, A Rosewood Resort, on Hawaii Island?
Select one

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ Not sure

S6. Which best describes your experience with luxury resorts on Hawaii Island?
Select one

☐ I have stayed at one or more

☐ I have researched or considered staying at one

☐ I have not researched or considered staying at one

Programming note: Terminate if S1 is outside 25–64 or unknown; S2 ≠ Yes; S3 is below $180,000 or undisclosed; S4 ≠ Yes; S5 ≠ No; or S6 indicates no research/consideration. Thank ineligible respondents and end the survey.

Part 3. Introduction

Thank you for participating! In the following questions, please think about how you would choose a luxury beachfront resort in Hawaii for a future leisure vacation. We are interested in your personal preferences and decision-making process. There are no right or wrong answers.

Part 4. Main Questionnaire (8 Questions)

Q1. When choosing a luxury beachfront resort in Hawaii, which THREE of the following attributes would most influence your decision?
Select exactly three (randomize response order)

☐ Dining and culinary experiences

☐ Personalized service

☐ Privacy and seclusion

☐ Room and accommodation design

☐ Hawaiian cultural experiences

☐ Nature and oceanfront setting

☐ Resort amenities and activities

Q2. How appealing would each of the following experiences be to you when considering a luxury resort in Hawaii?
For each statement, select one response: 1 – Not at all appealing; 2 – Slightly appealing; 3 – Moderately appealing; 4 – Very appealing; 5 – Extremely appealing.

Dining and culinary experiences ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Personalized service ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Privacy and seclusion ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Room and accommodation design ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Hawaiian cultural experiences ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Nature and oceanfront setting ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Resort amenities and activities ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Q3. Which ONE of these experiences would most motivate you to learn more about a luxury resort you have never visited?
Select one (randomize response order)

☐ Dining and culinary experiences

☐ Personalized service

☐ Privacy and seclusion

☐ Room and accommodation design

☐ Hawaiian cultural experiences

☐ Nature and oceanfront setting

☐ Resort amenities and activities

Q4. *"Kona Village, A Rosewood Resort, is a luxury beachfront resort on Hawaii Island. It offers standalone accommodations, dining venues, guest services, and recreational and cultural activities."*
Based only on the description above, how likely would you be to consider Kona Village for a future luxury vacation in Hawaii?
Select one

☐ 1 – Very unlikely

☐ 2 – Unlikely

☐ 3 – Neither likely nor unlikely

☐ 4 – Likely

☐ 5 – Very likely

Marketing Message Stimuli *(show before Q5)*

Please carefully read the following four promotional messages describing a potential stay at Kona Village, A Rosewood Resort. Imagine you are planning your next luxury vacation to Hawaii.

Message A (Property & Setting): "Experience Hawaii in a private standalone hale, surrounded by natural beauty and an oceanfront setting."

Message B (Dining): "Discover a luxury escape through distinctive dining experiences inspired by the flavors of Hawaii."

Message C (Service): "Enjoy a luxury getaway with attentive, personalized service throughout your stay."

Message D (Cultural Experiences): "Connect with Hawaii through cultural experiences inspired by the island's traditions and heritage."

Programming note: Randomize the order of the four messages consistently across Q5–Q6. These are hypothetical research stimuli, not official brand advertising. Verify factual claims before fielding.

Q5. How appealing is each of the four messages above to you as a potential first-time guest of Kona Village?
For each statement, select one response: 1 – Not at all appealing; 2 – Slightly appealing; 3 – Moderately appealing; 4 – Very appealing; 5 – Extremely appealing.

Message A ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Message B ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Message C ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Message D ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Q6. Which ONE of these messages would most increase your interest in considering Kona Village for a future vacation?
Select one

☐ Message A

☐ Message B

☐ Message C

☐ Message D

☐ None of these messages

Q7. After reviewing these messages, how likely would you be to consider Kona Village for a future luxury vacation in Hawaii?
Select one

☐ 1 – Very unlikely

☐ 2 – Unlikely

☐ 3 – Neither likely nor unlikely

☐ 4 – Likely

☐ 5 – Very likely

Q8. Which source would you be most likely to consult when deciding whether to book a luxury resort you have never visited?
Select one

☐ Guest reviews on travel booking websites

☐ Social media posts or videos from other travelers

☐ Official resort website

☐ Travel publications and editorial reviews

☐ Recommendations from friends or family

☐ Travel advisors or agents

☐ Other

Part 5. Classification Questions

C1. What type of travel party would you most likely travel with on your next luxury resort vacation?
Select one

☐ Romantic partner or spouse

☐ Family with children

☐ Multigenerational family

☐ Friends

☐ Solo

☐ Other

C2. Which U.S. region do you currently live in?
Select one

☐ West (including CA, WA, OR)

☐ Northeast

☐ Midwest

☐ South

☐ Other U.S. region or territory

Part 6. Closing

Thank you for completing our survey! Your responses will help us better understand what attracts travelers to luxury resort experiences and how resorts can communicate their offerings more effectively.

Researcher Notes (Not Shown to Respondents)

Analysis: Q1–Q3 attribute preferences; Q4 initial consideration; Q5 message appeal; Q6 most persuasive message; Q4 vs. Q7 descriptive pre/post consideration; Q8 preferred source; S3/C1/C2 subgroup comparisons.

Design caveats: This is a draft instrument for an exploratory sequential QUAL → QUANT study. Revise attributes and messages after interviews. The Q4–Q7 change does not establish causal message effects; random assignment to individual messages would be required for stronger causal comparisons. Convenience sampling limits population-level generalizability. Pilot test flow and mobile display; label every scale point.

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